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Black Students in VET: Learner Experiences in an English Metropolitan and Provincial Setting¹

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Abstract

Building on our earlier research this paper addresses the lived experience of black students in VET. It samples nine young people (male and female, 16-25), drawn from a northern provincial and metropolitan English city. It addresses, what has in recent years become an under-researched area, the lived experience of African-Caribbean and mixed heritage youth in VET. The paper points towards the salience of analyses of social capital, metropolitan and provincial cities as well as labour market conditions on these processes. In addition, it seeks to locate the discussion within its socio-economic context as well as the manner in which race is both historically and contemporaneously embedded in the division of labour.

Keywords

VET, race, labour market, management science, Taylorism, Fordism

1 The marginalisation of race and VET

This neglect is partly a consequence of researchers focusing on schools and higher education, principally as a potential route to upward social mobility and the manner in which these aspirations are constrained by racist practices. There is perhaps another reason for the neglect of VET which relates to the capitalist division of labour and the way this is entwined with racist processes. Research that has addressed the labour process in the US and the transition from Taylorism to Fordism, has illustrated the manner in which race is central to such processes rather than being an atavistic hangover from the past (Roediger & Esch, 2017; Doray, 1988). Doray refers to a ‘rational madness’ which in part has been reflected in Fordism but also in a racialised division of labour. Different racialised groups were deemed to have particular

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dispositions that aligned with particular types of labour. The difficulty faced by theorists who proposed such arguments is that they could not agree on any particular racialised hierarchy, or indeed who was to be included. Different groups such as the Irish, Jews, Slavs, Swedes and Black Americans were racialized and compared against one another in terms of their capacity to perform various types of manual labour (Roediger & Esch, 2017). Not dissimilar processes were present in Europe. We need only consider the manner in which the UK and the French drew on labour from their former colonies, with Germany utilising Turkish guest workers (Castle & Kosack, 1973). Goulbourne & Solomos (2003) commenting on the 1970s/80s, citing Ward and Jenkins (1984) remark, how at that time the participation of ethnic minorities in the labour market and wider society was thought to be shaped by dispositional values. They note,

there are two strong models of participation of minority ethnic communities in British society: the Jewish (represented as being socially, economically, and politically successful, and well integrated into the upper echelons of society) and the Irish (generally represented as being less successful and mainly outside the mainstream of British society). Subsequent groups ... followed this dual pattern (Goulbourne & Solomos, 2003, p. 333).

Asians were assumed to have followed the Jewish model whereas African-Caribbeans were aligned with the Irish model, being firmly placed within a racialised working class. There are a number of consequences that flow from this form of racialisation. Key amongst which is the positioning of African-Caribbeans within the working class, which is reflective of the essentialism of earlier historical accounts. The link between class destinies and VET may also in part, explain the neglect of the latter in critical analyses of race and education. Wallace (2018) draws our attention to the association of whiteness with the valorised cultural capital of the white middle class which serves to marginalise the capital of the black middle class (see Rollock et al., 2015). Whilst Ward and Jenkins (1984) were writing in the 1980s and Goulbourne and Solomos (2003) refer to analyses drawn from the 1970s/80s, Wallace's more contemporary ethnography provides examples of school teachers unthinkingly associating blackness with underachievement. Joseph, one of his respondents, commented:

There's a ... black identity that my white teachers try to strap onto us... They expect us to fail ... they expect us to struggle money wise... they expect us to fight each other ... When we challenge or exceed their expectations, it's like they can't even recognise us [as black]. (Wallace, 2018, p. 474)

For Wallace white teachers failed to recognise the cultural and social capital upon which black middle-class students could draw (and see Yosso, 2005).

Socio-economic context

In the EU, and indeed globally, the route to economic competitiveness is said to arise from the development of a knowledge economy. Education policies frequently emphasise the need to prepare young people for the putative fourth industrial revolution, enabling them to fully mobilise their talents, contribute to wider society and avoid social exclusion. Such notions have become a hegemonic feature of international policy debates. In this context, VET has been depicted as integral to economic and social justice agendas, with a significant body of education research addressing the way in which European systems aim to develop in young people the competences, skills and dispositions required at work (Mulder, 2017).

Papers location

In previous papers (Avis et al., 2017a, b) we mobilised Leonardo's (2005) conceptualisation of *race ambivalence*, which argued that whilst race is 'unreal' in that it is an incoherent scientific category, its effects are nevertheless real. These papers examined English research on relationship between race, ethnicity and VET, much of which has lain dormant since the structural accounts of the 1970/80s. Significant questions emerged from the literature: the marginalisation of black youth in VET, their allocation to low-level courses, and 'warehousing'. The latter concept, first developed in the 1970s, refers to the way in which particular fractions of working-class youth were effectively 'parked' on youth training schemes and low-level VET. They were, to use Blacker's (2013) term, effectively 'eliminated' from the labour market, a process particularly applicable to black (Caribbean, African, mixed race) male youth (Roberts, 2009).

Our earlier statistical analysis suggested that patterns of participation are changing with young people from certain ethnic minorities now less likely than their white counterparts to be on VET courses (Avis, Orr, & Warmington, 2017). This is a change from the earlier situation in which black youth were overrepresented in English further Education and significantly in low-level VET (and see Allen et al., 2016). Whilst our small-scale exploratory case studies found that there was some evidence of both continuity and change in relation to the experience of black youth in English further education and VET, there was also some evidence supporting our claim that in recent years there has been a "whitening" of FE. This should not, however, downplay processes of racialisation that impact upon FE/VET. FE remains an important educational site for black youth, and if we are to concern ourselves with questions of social justice, we need to address patterns of racialisation and their intersectionality with class and gender as part of a political praxis. The most recent statistical release suggests that the total participation rates in FE/VET in England have fallen by 30 per cent from 4.7 million in 2002/03 to 3.3 million in 2015/16 (ESFA, 2018). This is compared with participation rates among people under the age of 30 in HE that have risen steadily since 2006 and were 49 per cent in 2015-16 (DfE 2017a). Among 16- and 17-year olds in England in 2016, 32.5% were in state-funded schools, 11.5% were in sixth-form colleges, and 30% were in FE colleges (DfE, 2017b, p5). These statistics suggest the increasing marginalization of Further Education in the English educational landscape. However, the data it provides on the 'whitening' of FE is inconclusive (ESFA, 2018).

The current paper

The current paper moves beyond our earlier research by addressing the social capital available in black communities that facilitates the transition to VET. There is a worry with this type of analysis that Goulbourne and Solomos (2003) alert us to. Discussions concerned with the social capital and allied dispositions available to particular ethnic groups can readily fold into a deficit model that resonates with essentialist constructions of racialized groups. Reynolds (2013), whilst acknowledging that social capital can be ambiguous, draws our attention to the way it enables transitions to VET and beyond. Not dissimilarly Modood (2004), in a discussion of British South Asian and Chinese communities, draws on the notion of 'ethnic capital' which serves as a community resource. This leads us to consider the way the opportunity structure young people encounter is impacted by region, locality, the labour market as well as its positioning in a metropolitan or provincial city. Ball et al. (2000) draw our attention to the particularities of London as a global/metropolitan city. In a number of respects, such processes map onto European experiences and raise questions about specificity. Roberts (2009) for example, in a discussion of East and West Germany points towards the qualitatively different labour market contexts faced by young people in these distinct regions. Such arguments need to be

nuanced to take into account labour market conditions and the way in which these are played out in relation to race and ethnicity. Martin and Morrison (2003) note the spatial and constructed nature of labour markets as well as their porosity. Alongside a local labour market that features low waged intermittent work, or no work at all, there may be others lodged within a global labour market of high skilled/waged work. Such labour markets may overlap but will also be subject to ongoing change and construction. Thus, within a social formation, areas of full employment, high wages and putative skills gaps/mismatch sit alongside regions/localities characterised by multiple disadvantages and the lack of decent jobs. Similarly, Thelen and Busemeyer (2011) illustrate the shift from collectivism to segmentalism in German VET, whereby the latter refers to training that solely addresses the specific needs of employers.

2 Method

The interviews explore black learners' lived experiences, enabling examination of their routes into VET, pedagogic experience, their orientation towards the vocational and their specific experiences of Further Education colleges (the main provider of VET in England). By utilising semi-structured interviews, we were able to pursue particular lines of inquiry arising during the interview, allowing us to develop a fuller understanding of interviewees' interpretations of their VET experiences. The interviews were coded and thematically analysed. This is as yet a small-scale exploratory study for which we make no claims for generalisability or representativeness. Nevertheless, it offers some illumination and relatability to the experiences of black youth in metropolitan, provincial cities and disadvantaged contexts and with those who face similar circumstances elsewhere in Europe.

3 Findings

We found, for instance, that some of the black students we interviewed relied on 'cold knowledge' sources such as Google for initial information on VET pathways. Joe and Sarah, respondents from the provincial city, stated,

SJ: How did you know about the course?

Joe: I literally just looked online... I just typed in like 'Fitness Courses', and the Uni popped up and it said like an NVQ.

Sarah: I just did a lot of research online.

Not dissimilar comments were made by respondents in the metropolitan city. Charles commented,

Charles: But perhaps I was encouraged, maybe not explicitly, to undertake a vocational course, but that kind of meant that particular style of learning was something that was encouraged, particularly in my sort of GCSE years, so Year Ten and Year Eleven, that kind of hands-on learning approach and that actually reflected some of the courses that I took in GCSE

Nathan drew on his aunt who suggested the course he should take.

Nathan: To be honest, no teachers actually took me and said look, this is what you should do, or this is what I think you should do, or anything like that. It was just, they were just happy that I finished GCSEs, that I was kind of out of their hair.

Whereas some of Michael's teachers suggested a number of options as did his girlfriend:

Michael: First, my girlfriend at the time helped me there, sort of steered me in the right direction and a couple of the other teachers that were sort of giving me my options really ...A-Levels, they weren't really my thing ...it had to be something sport related, it had to be back to my roots basically and what I know. So, the BTech, it sort of fitted every criteria and it ended up being the perfect place for me really...

For some of our participants, the decision to enter FE/ VET was part of a push-pull dynamic. They had either decided that an 'academic' A-Level route was not for them or they felt dissatisfied with the school environment. Ty reflected on his decision to take up a sports (boxing) apprenticeship:

Ty: To be honest, there was no alternative. I had to, I felt like I had to do it because if I stayed at my High School, because I wasn't well behaved at my High School, so if I stayed at my High School, I don't think I had a realistic chance of succeeding or attaining well. So I think for myself, I had to look at it, right, I've finished High School, my GCSEs don't represent what I'm capable of, so I really have to go out there and I really have to start shaving a career pathway for myself. However, these alternatives, they were all my decision, I mean there was no influence at this stage from my parents, family or friends...

Michael: A-Levels, they weren't really my thing and I wasn't really looking to do anything else in terms of the A-Levels. It was, it had to be something sport related...

Such comments recalled Thompson's (2009) suggestion that for some working-class students, decisions to enter FE are shaped as much by students' sense of what they *cannot* achieve as what they *can* achieve. Charles commented on the relationship between his school experiences and his perception of himself as someone suited to VET:

Charles: I think I've always been quite a kind of hands-on or practical learner ...perhaps [at school] I was encouraged maybe not explicitly to undertake a Vocational Course, but that particularly kind of meant that particular style of learning was something that was encouraged, particularly in my sort of GCSE years, so Year Ten and Year Eleven, that kind of hands-on learning approach and that actually reflected some of the Courses that I took in GCSE.

While generally happy with his decision to take a Level 3 NVQ in Health Care, he had felt some initial ambivalence about the status of VET pathways and FE colleges.

SJ: ...what expectations did you have of that particular Qualification [NVQ3] at the time?

Charles: I think just to give me a good basis or a good understanding of kind of ...healthcare and where I wanted to perhaps try to develop a career. I think I expected it to, perhaps I expected it to be a bit, like going to a Further Education College, perhaps I expected it to be a bit like looked down upon, if that makes sense, particularly like where you had a lot of people doing A-Levels and so on and so forth. But I think for me and for what I was trying to achieve, I felt like that was, that was quite a good route.

However, we also found that, having opted for FE and for VET programmes, some of our participants had a sense of dislocation, feeling that their particular work/ skills interests were marginalized. Black students in fields such as hair and beauty sometimes found that their specific interests were not catered for, and that their VET qualifications left them on the periphery of the sector (e.g. renting chairs in salons).

SJ: How did you feel, you said on both (hairdressing) courses, you were the minority, how did you feel about that? Or did it not impact on you?

Maya: In the Beauty, it didn't impact as much, but in the Hairdressing it was, because like, when you have to work on each other, like they had no clue about my hair, like what to do with black hair, so yeah, that was hard... even the training dolls you use, it's all like European hair... From family experience and stuff, I am quite good with African-Caribbean hair, but you know, you want to know, what's the point if you're not going to even know how to do your own hair?

SJ: So how come you didn't take the course that taught about African-Caribbean hair?

Maya: They do actually offer it at the College, but the woman who taught it was on long-term sick and they kept saying oh we're going to employ someone else, but they never ended up doing it, and I don't know if that's just because there wasn't a need for it, or just they weren't bothered.

SJ: How did you feel about that, when you heard that?

Maya: Annoyed, I just wanted to do it (*laughs*), really, really. It angered me, but there was nothing you could do, and I did look into another African-Caribbean course in [provincial city]... there aren't any, or there weren't at the time.

Maya was constrained by provincial city's opportunity structure which offered very limited access to training for African-Caribbean hair. It seemed as if the opportunity structure and social networks available to our metropolitan young people were qualitatively different and provided greater access to training. Ty talked about the way in which a teacher at his school had encouraged him to go to college. This respondent felt that if he had remained in school, he would have 'messed about'. At college, he studied boxing and built up a close relationship with his personal tutor who offered him helpful advice and who was very keen that BME students succeeded. He stated,

Ty: [the college course] was heavily populated, BME and Asian populated area, so I had a lot of, I had a lot in common with everyone on the course, the students and especially the staff and my Personal Tutor.

Whereas the African-Caribbean hairdressers were in a minority on their course. Maya mentioned that "I think there were about twelve to fifteen people in the class. There were two black women, me and Barbara". In some respects, these accounts reflect on the opportunity structure found within local ecologies. Consequently, these affordances for networking and developing forms of community-based social capital will vary over time and place (Kerr, Dyson & Raffo, 2014).

In addition, some of these accounts bore some relation to research into VET in the 1980s that suggested black students were less likely to have direct proximity to 'real' workplaces – that is to say they were socially and culturally distanced from the workplace. In this instance, work experience was provided in simulated environments in FE or the premises of private training agencies. Joe, for example, was very quizzical about the training he had received from a private training agency.

Joe: The teachers very much sort of get on with it, do you know what I mean and then they had to go and do something else, so it wasn't really one to one, it wasn't really hands-on or anything like that. It was just you there, an environment for you to learn in, on your own, off your own back. If you wanted to do it, you could do it, if you didn't, you didn't, because it was government funded. So, I think that because of that reason and because of the attitude they had, they weren't really pushing you if that makes sense.

4 Conclusion

The study develops our understanding of the experiences of black students in VET. It relates these findings to empirical work not only in the UK but also to continental Europe (see for example Colding, 2006 and Szalai et al., 2009). It allows us to consider the significance of theoretical analyses of the VET experience of black youth with other minority ethnic groups in Europe, enabling an examination of both specificity and continuity. Importantly, in this paper, we have touched on the salience of analyses of social capital, metropolitan and provincial cities as well as labour market condition on these processes. In addition, the study also enables a consideration of the salience of gender and class on these processes. The study anticipates further qualitative and quantitative work in both the UK and Europe, building upon this and earlier research.

Appendix

Table 1 Respondents

Name	Age	VET	Part-time/Full-time	date graduated	Qualification	Funding
Joe	25	Level 2 Fitness Level 3 Recruitment	Part-time Part-time	2010 2016	NVQ	State
Sarah	24	Level 2 Hairdressing Level 3 Special effect and media make up	Part-time Part-time	2015	NVQ	State
Clare	19	Level 1 Hairdressing Level 2 Hairdressing Level 3 Hairdressing	Part-time Part-time Part-time	on-going		State
Maya	25	Level 1 Hairdressing Aromatherapy, Swedish massage Level 2 Beauty therapy	Full-time Part-time	2013 2014		State State
Charles	29	Level 3, Health and Social Care, BTEC National Diploma		2007		State
Ty	22	Level 3, Sport, Exercise and Coaching, BTEC National Diploma	Part-time	2014		State
Nathan	25	Level 3, Sport, Health and Fitness, BTEC National Diploma		2011		State
Michael	25	Level 3, Sport and Exercise Fitness, BTEC National Certificate		2011		State
Carl	28	Level 3, Leisure and Sport, ACCESS		2011		State

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Biographical notes

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Paul Warmington is a Professor in the School of Education, University of Birmingham. He is a founder member of the University's Centre for Research in Race and Education. Paul has taught, researched and written extensively on race, education and social justice, often focusing on widening participation and post-compulsory education and training. He is series co-editor of Palgrave Macmillan's new *Studies in Race, Inequality and Social Justice in Education* book series.